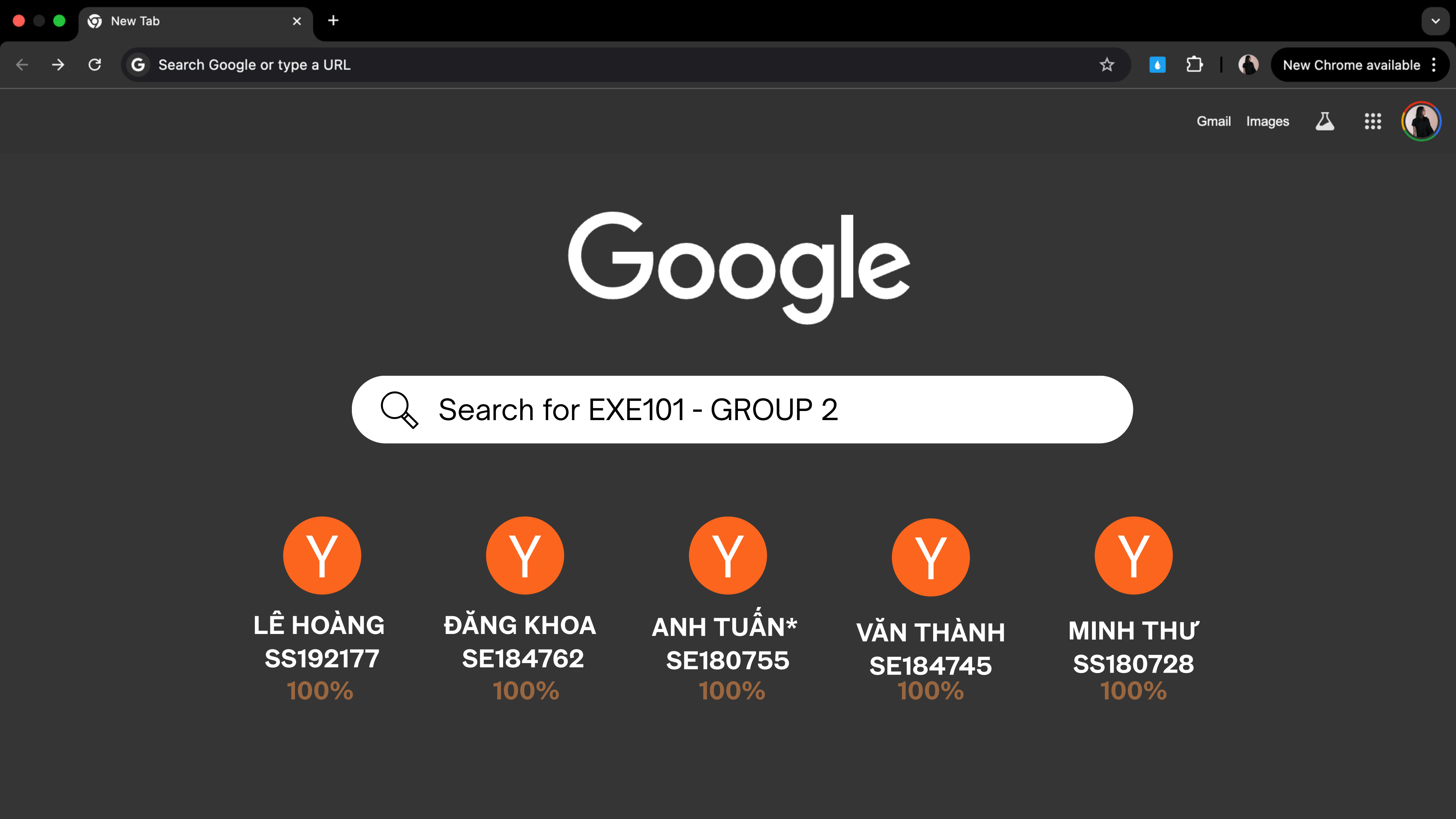




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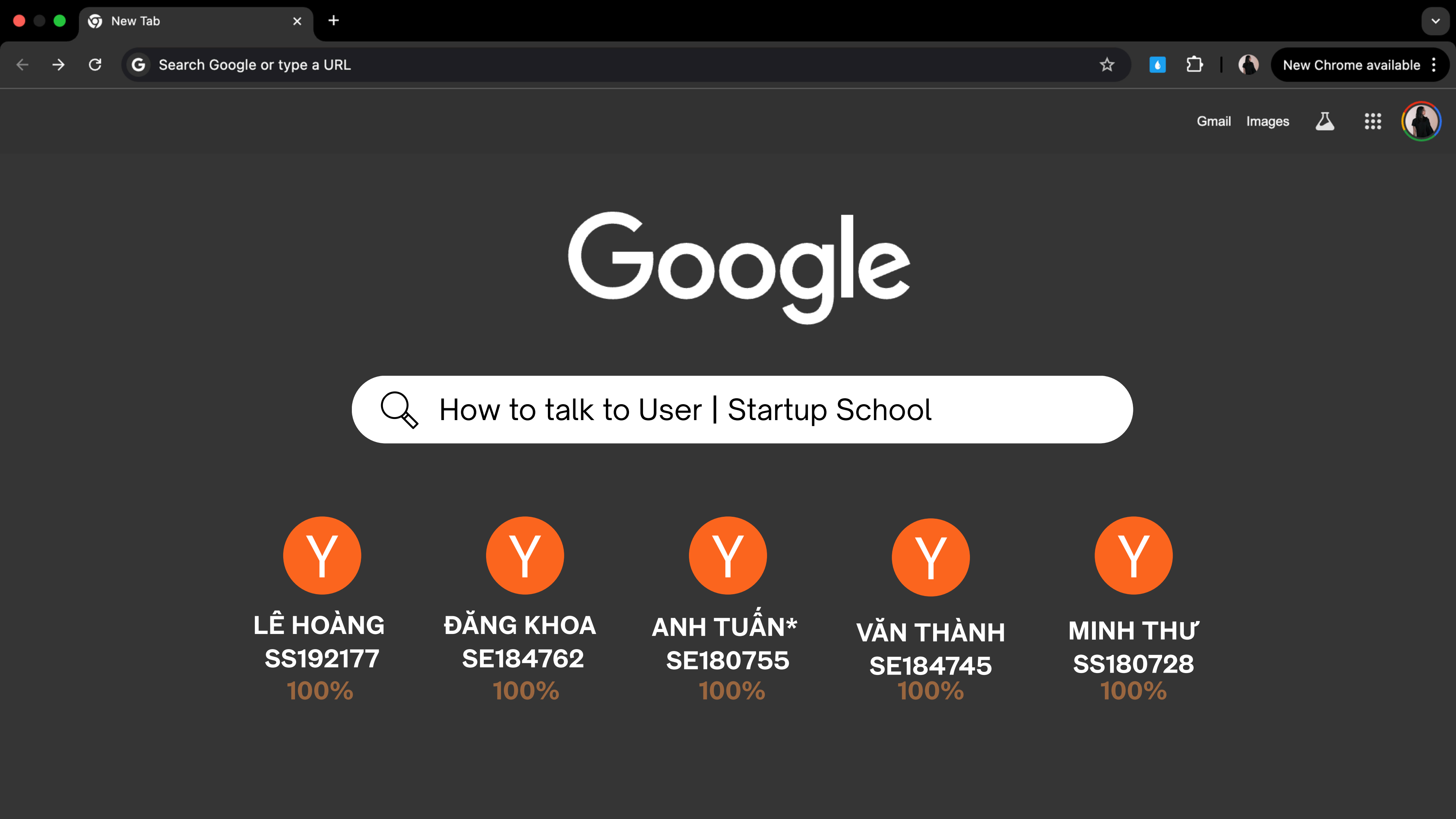
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How to talk to User | Startup School



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WHY TALKING TO USERS MATTERS



Many people believe startup ideas come from sudden moments of inspiration.

Great founders do not rely on assumptions, they learn directly from real user experiences.

QUICK RECAP

In reality, the strongest ideas are shaped through continuous conversations with users throughout a company's lifetime

Talking to users helps teams validate whether a problem is real, painful, and worth solving.

IDEAS ARE NOT RANDOM BREAKTHROUGHS



A common misconception is that successful startup ideas appear suddenly or randomly.

Founders who regularly talk to users are more likely to identify hidden needs and unmet problems

Continuous user conversations reduce the risk of building products that nobody wants.

In practice, successful ideas evolve through observation, iteration, and feedback.

THE 6 KEY QUESTIONS TO ASK

1

"How do you perform (X) today?"

Describe last time you performed X: steps, tools, time, people,

2

"What is the hardest part of doing (X)?"

Explain the hardest part of X: causes, frequency, consequences, examples.

3

"Why is it difficult?"

Probe root causes: missing data, unclear steps, tools, approvals, constraints.

4

"How often do you have to do (X)?"

Ask frequency and volume: daily/weekly, peaks, role differences, impact estimates.

THE 6 KEY QUESTIONS TO ASK



"Why is solving this problem important to your family?"

Tie problem to business impact: revenue, cost, compliance, customer experience.



"What are you doing to solve it right now?"

Identify current workarounds: spreadsheets, scripts, tools, costs, time spent, tolerance.

Focusing on promising sectors with favorable characteristics will maximize your startup's chances of success.

THINGS YOU MUST ABSOLUTELY AVOID



- ✗ Ask “Will you use this?”
- ✗ Ask for feature ideas
- ✗ Yes / No questions
- ✗ Two questions at once
- ✗ Confuse problems with solutions

FROM INTERVIEWS TO BUILDING AN MVP



MAINTAINING USER RELATIONSHIPS

Create Communities



Slack / WhatsApp

- Facebook

Make Them Feel Special



- Early access
- Insider feeling
- Excel is baseline



Respond Fast

Feedback → Update
Build trust



AIRBNB (BRIAN CHESKY)

PROBLEM

- Hosts lacked trust in a new platform
- Founders didn't understand real host concerns

SOLUTION

- Founder lived with hosts and talked daily
- Direct communication via personal phone numbers

KEY INSIGHTS

- Direct, in-person conversations reveal real user problems
- Trust is often a bigger barrier than product features
- Living the user experience gives founders deeper insights
- Close founder-user relationships enable faster decisions
- Early-stage qualitative feedback can outperform metrics

GMAIL (PAUL BUCHHEIT)

PROBLEM

- Users requested Gmail to display the inbox list and email content on the same screen.
- The team initially assumed this was a UI or design preference

SOLUTION

- Paul Buchheit investigated why users wanted this feature instead of implementing it blindly.
- He discovered the real issue was slow loading speed, not layout.

KEY INSIGHTS

- Users often describe solutions, not the real problem.
- Good user conversations uncover root causes.

THE OUTCOME

- PERFORMANCE IMPROVEMENTS BECAME THE PRIORITY
- FASTER AND SMOOTHER EMAIL EXPERIENCE
- GMAIL SET A NEW STANDARD FOR WEB-BASED EMAIL PRODUCTS

LESSON LEARNT

01 Focus on the problem, not the features.

Users are often good at identifying problems but poor at proposing solutions; your job is to understand their pain points rather than blindly implementing every feature they request.

02 Avoid leading questions.

Don't ask whether they use the product, as they may say "yes" just to please you; instead, ask about their actual past and current behaviors.

03 Observe its actions instead of just listening to its commands.

If possible, observe how they actually perform the task (e.g., screen sharing), since changing user behavior is very difficult.

04 Determining value by willingness to pay:

Check whether users are paying for alternative solutions (even Excel); to replace them, your product must be clearly and significantly better.

05 Build direct relationships.

Don't hide behind "do-not-reply" emails. Create Slack or WhatsApp groups to stay connected with early adopters, make them feel special, and get a quick response from you.

